FREE DISCUSSION SHEET · YEARS 10 AND 11

Talking about The Social Reckoning

Aaron Sorkin's film about the 2021 Facebook leak is in UK cinemas and some of your pupils will have seen it. This sheet separates the record from the drama, so a class can talk about it without either dismissing it or taking it as a documentary.

Before you start

- Tell your DSL first. The film is rated 15 in the UK and mentions a child's self harm, so check your school's policy before showing any clip to Year 10.
- Talk about the film and its characters, never about ourselves or anyone we know. Questions can be anonymous.
- Close by saying where help is: a trusted adult in school, Childline on 0800 1111, Samaritans on 116 123.

On the record

- Frances Haugen took tens of thousands of pages of Facebook's internal research and filed at least eight complaints with US regulators.
- The Wall Street Journal published the Facebook Files in September 2021, including Instagram's research on teenage girls and a 2018 feed change staff warned was rewarding toxic reshares.
- She gave evidence to the US Senate and to the UK Parliament committee on the draft Online Safety Bill, which cites her throughout its report.

Drama, by the film's own account

- Sorkin says he invented conversations and changed the timeline. He calls his film a painting.
- Several characters are invented or blended, and the reporter is written as a composite.
- Writers who know the story say the first contact is moved earlier and the route to the Instagram research is invented. The findings shown are real.
- Check the closing cards: third party fact checking ended in the US in 2025, not everywhere.

What the leaked research did and did not show

A slide read "We make body image issues worse for one in three teen girls." It was real. It applied to girls who already struggled with body image, came from internal surveys and focus groups, and was not designed to prove cause and effect. A warning about some young people, not a measurement of all of them. Across large populations, researchers find the average link between social media and wellbeing is small, with more risk at some ages and for some young people. Ofcom calls personalised feeds children's main pathway to harmful content, and the law now requires risky feeds to filter out the most harmful content and reduce the rest.

Four questions for the class

1. **What do you think was real, and how could you check?**
   Media literacy: a dramatisation is a source too. Who made it, and what did they change?
2. **Who did the film want you to blame? Is that the whole story?**
   Platforms, regulators, users, parents: who can change what?
3. **How would someone your age notice a feed pulling them somewhere they did not choose?**
   Narrower, darker, repetitive, hard to stop.
4. **What should platforms have to do, and what can a person do in the moment?**
   Design duties under the Online Safety Act; mute, unfollow, reset, leave, tell someone.

THE SKILL TO LEAVE WITH

Narrower? Darker? Not my choice? Stop, and tell someone.

Taught in full in the Guided Childhood schools scheme: KS4, Radicalisation and misogyny; KS3, Bodies, image and pressure online.

Sources: CBS 60 Minutes, Oct 2021; US Senate hearing, 5 Oct 2021; Joint Committee on the Draft Online Safety Bill report, Dec 2021; Reuters interview with Aaron Sorkin, Oct 2026; Slate, 9 Oct 2026; Meta's annotated research deck, Sept 2021; NPR, 6 Oct 2021; Orben and Przybylski 2019; Ofcom Protection of Children Codes, 2025; BBFC. Free to copy for use in schools.